

Urdu, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to contemporary Urdu

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Starter edition — sixteen short lessons in four cumulative chapters.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/urdu/lessons/

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How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Urdu. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the letters, sounds, and grammar it needs, connects it to words you may already know, and ends with a retrieval prompt. Read Urdu from right to left, but do not memorize an alphabet before you meet useful language.

Urdu is traditionally printed in the descending Nastaliq style. This starter edition uses the vendored Noto Naskh Arabic font as a legible, deterministic fallback while a static Nastaliq font is evaluated separately. The language, joining behavior, and right-to-left order are Urdu; the type style is labelled honestly rather than silently presented as Nastaliq.

Urdu vocabulary makes several histories visible. Its grammar and much everyday vocabulary are Indo-Aryan and closely related to Hindi, while Persian and Arabic have contributed a large literary and formal layer. Etymology here is a memory aid, not a claim that a borrowed word is any less fully Urdu today.

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Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, thank, answer yes, answer no. Four short expressions establish right-to-left reading, joining, omitted short vowels, long vowels, respectful *jī*, and one Urdu nasal sign. Companion lessons: UR-C01-*.md.

1.1 سلام (*salām*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Urdu runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ā long ā, م *m*. Letters usually join inside a word. The tall ل does not connect to the following letter, so the final م begins a new stroke group. No other letters are due yet.

Where the expression came from

Salām is a greeting and the word “peace.” Urdu received it through the Persian-Arabic literary world. Its consonants **s–l–m** belong to a Semitic family concerned with peace, safety, and wholeness. Persian *salām*, Arabic *salām*, and Hebrew *shalom* make the historical family especially visible.

Use it now

Say سلام to begin a friendly exchange. For now the safest reply is the same word: A says سلام; B answers سلام. One useful move is enough.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries long *ā*? Point to ل, cover the romanization, and say *salām* once.

1.2 شکریہ (*shukriyā*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Urdu normally leaves short vowels unmarked. Read the visible guide: ش *sh*, ک *k*, ر *r*, ی *y/i*, ہ final *h*-shape. The learned whole supplies the short *u* and *i*, while the ending is pronounced long *ā*. First remember one joined word, not every possible letter form.

Where the expression came from

The central consonants **sh–k–r** belong to the Arabic family for gratitude; Arabic *shukran* is a close comparison. Urdu *shukriyā* reflects its long Persian-Arabic lexical history and is an ordinary modern Urdu expression.

Use it now

Build a two-step chain: سلام *salām* — hello; شکریہ *shukriyā* — thank you. Keep the second word in three light beats: *shuk-ri-yā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which new letter begins شکریہ? Point to ش, say *sh*, then produce *salām* — *shukriyā* without looking.

1.3 جی ہاں (*jī hā*) — yes, respectfully**Read only what this expression needs**

This answer has two small words. In جی, ج gives *j* and ی stretches the vowel to *ī*. In ہاں, the final ہ is **nūn ghunna**: it nasalizes long *ā* rather than adding a strong English *n*. Let a little air pass through the nose.

Use it now

ہاں means “yes.” Adding جی makes the response attentive and respectful; جی can also answer by itself. Learn the safely courteous whole first: جی ہاں *jī hā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which final sign nasalizes the vowel? Point to ں. Then answer politely: جی ہاں.

1.4 نہیں (*nahī*) — no, and later not**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse ہ, ی, and nasal ں; add ن *n* at the right edge. The result is نہیں *nahī*. Stretch *ī* slightly and nasalize it; do not add a separate forceful *n* at the end.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the Persian-Arabic vocabulary that opened the chapter, *nahī* belongs to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan core. Hindi *nahī* is the same spoken word written in a different script. The shared form previews close grammatical kinship without making Hindi script a prerequisite.

Use it now

As a complete answer, نہیں means “no.” Inside a later sentence it will also mean “not,” but that second job can wait. Contrast only: جی ہاں — yes; نہیں — no.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the chain hello, thank you, yes, no. Then read سلام, شکریہ, جی ہاں, نہیں in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

The first chapter supplied social moves. This one adds one sentence and one word-order fact: Urdu places the present copula at the end. Companion lesson: UR-C02-mera-naam.md.

2.1 میرا نام ... ہے — my name is ...

Read the Urdu phrase from right to left while keeping its spoken word order:

میرا نام سارا ہے۔
merā nām Sārā hai — My name is Sara.

Read only what this expression needs

Nearly every shape is recycled. میرا begins with م from سلام, then reuses ی, ر, and ا. نام reuses ن, ا, and م. In final ہے, the only new form is ے, called *barī ye*; here the whole word is pronounced *hai*. Learn that diphthong with the word.

Use it now

Assemble four slots:

1. میرا *merā* — my;
2. نام *nām* — name;
3. your name;
4. ہے *hai* — is.

The reusable pattern is **my + name + NAME + is**. Urdu places *hai* at the end. Replace Sara with your name and keep every other slot.

Where the expression came from

Nām continues an old Indo-Aryan form related to Sanskrit *nāman* and, much farther back, English *name*. The possessive *merā* and copula *hai* also belong to Urdu’s inherited grammar. The sentence therefore follows the Indo-Aryan layer that Urdu shares closely with Hindi, even though Urdu writes it in the Perso-Arabic script.

One-minute checkpoint

Where does “is” go? At the end. Point to **ہے**, then replace Sara with your own name and say the full four-slot sentence once.

What is deliberately deferred

Urdu possessives agree with the noun they describe; *merā* has this form because *nām* is grammatically masculine, not because of the speaker’s gender. That rule, other possessive forms, and the rest of the copula paradigm belong to later lessons. The fixed introduction works for every speaker now.

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — three relationships inside “you”

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Say **merā nām ... hai** with your own name. To ask the other person’s name, begin with the respectful form.

You’ll want to know first — three forms

Urdu	read	use
آپ	<i>āp</i>	respectful: a new adult, elder, or anyone you wish to honor
تم	<i>tum</i>	familiar: friends and peers
تو	<i>tū</i>	intimate, or downward; unsafe as a beginner default

آپ begins with Ā, an alif carrying the long *ā* mark, then پ *p*. تم and تو share *t*. In تو, و carries long *ū*.

Grammar Lens: choose the relationship first

English flattened these choices into one *you*. Urdu keeps three. Use **āp** in a first meeting. Move to **tum** when the relationship supports familiarity. Save **tū** for relationships where you already know it is welcome; used badly, it can sound belittling.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tum/tū belong to the old Indo-European familiar-“you” family: Sanskrit *tvam*, English **thou**, and Latin *tū* are relatives. **Āp** followed another route: a word connected with “self/oneself” became honorific address.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: a new adult — **āp**]
- [YOU SAY: a friend — **tum**]
- [YOU SAY: the old family — **tum, tvam, thou**]

Wrap-up recall

Which form is safest when unsure? (**Āp**.) Which familiar forms share history with English *thou*? (**Tum/tū**.)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Cultural Notes.

3.2 کیا — what

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Which “you” opens a respectful first meeting? (آپ, *āp*.) Now add the question word.

You’ll want to know first — کیا

کیا — *kyā* — **what**

Read right to left: ک *k*, ی supplying the *y* glide here, then ! long *ā*. The same ی carried long *ī* in جی and نہیں. Its job depends on the word; here the learned shape is *kyā*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu **kyā** and Hindi **kyā** are the same inherited Indo-Aryan word in different scripts. Their history reaches Sanskrit *kim* and the old Indo-European *k/kw-* question family behind English **wh-** words such as *what*, *who*, and *which*. The bridge helps memory; Urdu کیا remains the form you must read here.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **kyā** — what]
- [YOU READ: کیا as **k** + **yā**]
- [YOU SAY: the family — **kyā**, **what**, **who**, **which**]

Wrap-up recall

Which letter acts as *y* here but as long *ī* in جی؟ (ی.) What does کیا mean? (**What**.)

3.3 آپ کا نام — ask a name respectfully

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Recall **āp** “you,” **kyā** “what,” and the answer **merā nām ... hai**. The question reuses all three.

The exchange

آپ کا نام — *āp kā nām kyā hai?* — **What is your name?**

Build it in spoken order:

you + **kā** + name + what + is?

Āp kā means “your” in this frame. The possessive form agrees with the thing owned: **nām** is masculine singular, so use **kā**. Keep that one pairing; the full *kā/kī/ke* system can wait. As in your answer, **hai** stays at the end.

Script: the question mark

Urdu ends the question with ؟, curved for a right-to-left line. Begin at آپ on the right and reach the punctuation at the far left.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **āp k̄ā nām kyā hai?**]
- [YOU SAY: ask, then answer — **merā nām ... hai**]
- [YOU POINT: to ؟ at the end]

Wrap-up recall

Ask once without romanization. Where does **hai** remain? (At the end.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

3.4 آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی — pleased to meet you

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Ask **āp k̄ā nām kyā hai?** and answer **merā nām ... hai**. This fixed response now closes the meeting.

The exchange

آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ *āp se mil kar khushī huī* **Pleased to meet you.**

For now, hold three meaning-sized chunks:

- **āp se** — with you
- **mil kar** — having met
- **khushī huī** — happiness happened

That yields the memorable literal picture: “**Having met you, happiness happened.**” The phrase is one social move; later lessons can generalize *se*, *-kar*, and past agreement one at a time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Khushī “happiness” comes from Persian **khosh/khush** “pleasant, happy.” **Mil** “meet” and **huī** “happened” belong to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan grammar. The sentence therefore joins Urdu’s two major historical layers without becoming any less ordinary Urdu.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **āp se | mil kar | khushī huī** in three beats]
- [YOU SAY: the literal picture — “having met you, happiness happened”]
- [YOU SAY: which word came through Persian — **khushī**]

Wrap-up recall

Say the response once as a whole. Which chunk means “happiness happened”? (**Khushī huī.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions.*

3.5 Practice — a complete Urdu name exchange

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — *Salām!* B: سلام! — *Salām!* A: آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ — *Āp kā nām kyā hai?* B: میرا نام سارا ہے۔ — *Merā nām Sārā hai.* A: آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ — *Āp se mil kar khushī huī.* B: شکریہ۔ — *Shukriyā.*

Every line is already known. **Āp** keeps the meeting respectful; **hai** stays at the end of both name sentences; ؟ ends the question at the line’s left.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: both voices, using your own name]
- [YOU SAY: the exchange again without romanization]
- [YOU SAY: only the three name moves — question, answer, response]

Wrap-up recall

Run the meeting once from **salām** to **shukriyā**. If a line stalls, review only that micro-lesson.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

4.1 کیسی / کیسے — “how” follows the addressee

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Say **kyā** “what.” Urdu’s next question word begins with the same **k** family, but its ending changes with the person being addressed.

The two words

Urdu	read	use in the respectful question
کیسے	<i>kaise</i>	addressing a man
کیسی	<i>kaisī</i>	addressing a woman

Both begin ک *k* + ی carrying the *ai* sound. At the left edge, کیسے ends in broad ے *e*, while کیسی ends in ی long *ī*. Read the whole word before isolating the final shape.

Grammar Lens: one agreement contrast

English keeps *how* unchanged. Urdu makes this describing form agree with the person addressed: **kaise** for a man, **kaisī** for a woman. Learn only this pair today—not a table of adjective endings. Respectful **āp** itself remains the same for everyone.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: addressing a man — **kaise**]
- [YOU SAY: addressing a woman — **kaisī**]
- [YOU POINT: broad final ے versus long-ī ی]

Wrap-up recall

Which form addresses a man? (**Kaise**.) A woman? (**Kaisī**.)
Source: *Basic Urdu*: Formal Conversation.

4.2 آپ / ہیں؟ کیسے آپ — ask respectfully

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Choose respectful **āp**. Then choose **kaise** for a man or **kaisī** for a woman. One final copula completes the question.

The exchange

to a man: آپ کیسے ہیں؟ — *āp kaise haiṅ?* to a woman: آپ کیسی ہیں؟ — *āp kaisī haiṅ?*

The order is **you + how + are?** Keep *haiṅ* final, just as *hai* stayed final in the name question. Respectful **āp** takes this plural-shaped copula even when speaking to one person.

Grammar Lens: respect does not erase agreement

Both lines are respectful. The choice between **kaise** and **kaisī** tracks the person addressed, not greater or lesser politeness. If you do not know how a person wishes to be addressed, listen for their usage or ask rather than guess; the grammar lesson does not replace social judgment.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: to a man — **āp kaise haiṅ?**]
- [YOU SAY: to a woman — **āp kaisī haiṅ?**]
- [YOU KEEP: respectful **āp** and final **haiṅ** in both]

Wrap-up recall

What stays the same in both lines? (**Āp ... haiñ.**) What changes? (**Kaise / kaisī.**)

Sources: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation and Personal Pronouns* with “To Be”.

4.3 میں ... ہوں — one frame for “I am ...”

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Ask **āp kaise haiñ?** You know the respectful “you are” ending **haiñ**. Your answer needs the first-person pair “I ... am.”

You’ll want to know first — the frame

میں ... ہوں — *main ... hūn* — I am ...

main means “I.” Final ں marks a nasal ending. *hūn* means “am” and carries long *ū* with و, followed again by nasal ں. Leave a space for the state word that comes next.

Grammar Lens: the verb closes the frame

Urdu puts the copula at the end:

main + [state] + hūn — I + [state] + am

Learn only this first-person frame. You do not need the full copula chart to answer one wellbeing question. Notice the useful contrast: respectful **āp ... haiñ**, but first-person **main ... hūn**.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **main** — I]
- [YOU SAY: **hūn** — am]
- [YOU FRAME: **main ... hūn**, leaving the middle open]

Wrap-up recall

Which word opens the answer? (**Maiñ.**) Which copula closes it? (**Hūñ.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”.

4.4 ٹھیک — “fine,” “well,” and “correct”

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Open and close the answer frame: **maiñ** ... **hūñ**. The middle now gets one high-frequency state word.

You’ll want to know first — the word

ٹھیک — *ṭhīk* — fine, well, correct

The first sound is retroflex and aspirated: curl the tongue slightly back for ٹ *ṭ*, then release a puff marked by ھ. A plain English *t* is a useful first approximation while the contrast settles. ی carries long *ī* before final ک *k*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu ٹھیک and Hindi *ṭhīk* are the same everyday Hindustani word. Their grammar is closely shared; their scripts make different literary histories visible. This Urdu lesson leaves the Hindi side romanized: mixed-language practice may show both scripts only after each form has been learned in its own track.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **ṭhīk** — fine, well]
- [YOU FEEL: tongue slightly back, then a small puff]
- [YOU CONNECT: Urdu ٹھیک ↔ Hindi *ṭhīk*]

Wrap-up recall

Where will **ṭhīk** go in the frame **maiñ** ... **hūñ**? (In the middle.)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Greetings and Introductions.

4.5 شکر یہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں — “I am fine, thank you”

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Fill the frame **main** ... **hūn** with **ṭhīk**, then recall Chapter 1’s **shukriyā**.

The exchange

شکر یہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں *Main ṭhīk hūn, shukriyā.* I am fine, thank you.

No word is new. The step is assembling the words quickly enough to answer a real person.

Grammar Lens: keep the copula final

The core reply is:

I + fine + am → **main ṭhīk hūn**

English places “am” after “I”; Urdu closes the clause with **hūn**. **Shukriyā** comes after the completed answer as the courtesy move you already own.

Guided Practice

- [YOU BUILD: **main** + **ṭhīk** + **hūn**]
- [YOU ADD: **shukriyā**]
- [YOU SAY: the full reply without translating each word]

Wrap-up recall

Which word must close the core answer? (**Hūn**.)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation*.

4.6 Practice — an Urdu wellbeing exchange

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Choose the question ending for the person addressed, then retrieve the complete answer before looking below.

The exchange

A to a man: سلام! آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaise haiñ?* A to a woman: سلام! آپ کیسی ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaisī haiñ?* B: ٹھیک میں۔ *Main ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā.*

The question keeps respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** while **kaise/kaisī** agrees with the addressee. The reply is unchanged for the speaker's gender: **ṭhīk** does not change, and first-person **hūñ** closes the line.

Grammar Lens: separate grammar from guessing

The two question forms are a grammatical contrast, not an instruction to infer someone's identity. In real interaction, follow the person's own language or ask. The stable beginner default is respect: **āp ... haiñ**.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: the man-addressed exchange]
- [YOU SAY: the woman-addressed exchange]
- [YOU ANSWER: **main ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā** after either question]

Wrap-up recall

Run both question variants once. If the choice stalls, review only **kaise/kaisī**; if the answer order stalls, review only **main ... hūñ**.

Chapter 5

Take Leave

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

5.1 خدا — the first half of an Urdu farewell

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Run one known wellbeing exchange. Chapter 5 will add only the move that ends it.

You'll want to know first — one word

خدا — *khudā* — **God**

Read from right to left: خ *kh* + د *d* + ا long *ā*. The short *u* is learned with the word and is normally unwritten. Let **kh** come from farther back than English *h*, but keep the sound relaxed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu borrowed **khudā** from Persian **khodā**, whose older Middle Persian ancestor *xwadāy* meant “lord.” Learn the Urdu sound and script first; the Persian connection then explains why both tracks will share the phrase’s first historical layer.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **khudā** — God]
- [YOU READ: خدا from the right edge]

- [YOU CONNECT: Urdu **khudā** ← Persian **khodā**]

Wrap-up recall

Which final letter carries long **ā**? (l.) Which short vowel must be remembered with the word? (u.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*; Wiktionary: خدا.

5.2 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Read خدا and say **khudā**. Keep it separate while one second word is added.

You’ll want to know first — one word

حافظ — *hāfiz* — guardian, protector

Read ح ا ف ا ح from right to left. ا carries long **ā**. Final ط is pronounced **z** in this Urdu word. The short *i* is heard in **hāfiz** but is normally not written as a separate letter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arabic **ḥāfiz** is an active participle from **ḥ-f-z**, “guard, preserve.” Urdu receives **hāfiz** through its Persian-Arabic literary layer. Keep “guardian” as the useful meaning; the three-consonant root is a memory hook.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **hāfiz** — guardian, protector]
- [YOU READ: حافظ]
- [YOU CONNECT: Arabic **ḥ-f-z** — guard, preserve]

Wrap-up recall

What does **hāfiz** contribute to the farewell? (The idea of guarding or protecting.)

Source: American Heritage Dictionary: *hafiz*.

5.3 حافظ خدا — goodbye

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Retrieve **khudā** and **hāfiz** separately: “God” + “guardian.” Now use the two known pieces as one parting move.

The two words — put the known pieces together

حافظ خدا — *khudā hāfiz* — goodbye

Urdu keeps a visible space between the two words. Read خدا first, then حافظ, and preserve that space in the complete spelling حافظ خدا. Say the whole expression smoothly.

Grammar Lens — a whole social move

The protective sense is “God [be] guardian,” but everyday speakers use the formula simply as **goodbye**. No new verb or agreement ending is needed. It is a reliable polite close for the short interaction learned so far.

Script Bridge — shared history, local spacing

Urdu حافظ خدا and Persian خداحافظ share the same historical pieces. Urdu keeps the visible space in this course; Persian normally joins them. Mixed practice may compare the two only now that each local phrase is independently readable.

Guided Practice

- [YOU BUILD: **khudā** + **hāfiz**]
- [YOU READ: spaced Urdu حافظ خدا]
- [YOU USE: say it when the interaction ends]

Wrap-up recall

Where is the local writing contrast? (Urdu shows a space; Persian joins its spelling.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

5.4 Practice — open, check, and close

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Retrieve the known expression for the beginning and the new expression for the end. Keep the middle unchanged.

The exchange — the complete interaction

A: سلام آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaise haiṅ?* B: ہوں، ٹھیک میں *hūn, ṭhīk mīn*.
 A: شکر ہے۔ *Shukr hai.* B: خدا حافظ۔ *Khudā hāfiz.*
 A: خدا حافظ۔ *Khudā hāfiz.*

Every line is already learned. **Salām** opens; **khudā hāfiz** closes. The same farewell works for both speakers, so this practice adds no gender choice, pronoun, or copula form.

Guided Practice

- [YOU CHOOSE: meeting begins → **salām**]
- [YOU CHOOSE: interaction ends → **khudā hāfiz**]
- [YOU RUN: both voices once with script, once without romanization]

Wrap-up recall

Run the full exchange once. If the final line stalls, return only to the assembled-farewell lesson.

Sources for this starter edition

Script descriptions follow Northwestern University’s open Zero Zabar Urdu-alphabet materials. Chapter 4’s wellbeing forms and register contrast, together with Chapter 5’s farewell, follow Michigan State University’s open *Basic Urdu*. The companion Markdown lessons carry the inline etymology citations and are the canonical short-practice source for this edition.